I Love Everybody

By Lori Notaro

LORI: **(Pg 113-132)** I was about to do a bad, bad thing. I knew it. I just couldn't help it. As soon as I saw that big fat hand reach up and grab the last two chocolate chip cookie nuggets from the sample tray, I knew it was my signal. I was going in for the kill. I'm a bad girl. And I can prove it.

INTRODUCTION

It's something that we struggle with daily -- it eats us up and causes stress and anger -- annoying people. You know those people. They cut in line, are rude to you in the office or at the restaurant, cut you off in traffic, talk loudly about obnoxious things, play loud music when you're trying to concentrate, interrupt you. I could go on and on. Lori Notaro decided that a new perspective on others would solve her problem. Her new mantra . . . "I Love Everybody." Let's see how it works out!

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LORI: I am not exactly a people person. Not exactly. You see, when I was born, God gave me an ounce of patience that was supposed to last me a lifetime, but it turns out I used all of it up during the first week.

I am not indiscriminately mean; I must be provoked first. I would classify myself as a Pointer-Outer of Extraordinary Acts of Incredible Foolishness. Some people would call these experiences meltdowns, but I would rather consider them Opportunities to Enlighten. For example:

- If you are sitting behind me in a movie and you feel the need to converse as freely as if you are in your living room, I will "Shhhh!" you and then I will ask you for ten dollars. I cannot grasp the need to talk in a movie theater.
- If you cut me off in traffic like you've got someone in the passenger seat whose severed limb is floating in an Igloo cooler on his lap, then suddenly and inexplicably slam on your brakes for no apparent reason, I will scream, maniacally, and point my finger at you. This

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- If you try to sneak two weeks' worth of groceries through the express line and think that no one will notice, I will look at your cart, look at you, and then shake my head in utter and obvious disgust. I'm done tolerating your type. I mean it. I have the ability to count to fifteen and I will USE IT ON YOU.
- If I happen to be looking out the window and see you allow your dog to take a *poop* in my yard, I will run outside with a pen and a piece of paper and query, "Hey, can I have your address? Because my dog will probably have to crap in the next hour or two, and I'm bringing her to *your* house to do it."

So I guess I am mean, I can admit that much . . . [And then in that millisecond of reflection] I hatched a brilliant, brilliant, magnificent plan: I would immediately embark on a life as a Nice People Person Person.

Really, I said to myself, how much energy could it take to be nice? A whole lot less than being angry, hostile, and frustrated nearly every time you encountered one of the Foolish, which could realistically be sixty times in one single minute if you were at the movies, the grocery store . . . . driving someplace. All you had to do to be nice was smile and nod your head. Smile and nod. And sometimes toss in a "My, what a pretty dress!" or an "Aren't you delightful?"

So I practiced smiling and nodding, and what a piece of cake! To think I could have been doing this all along! After a couple of hours, I felt I was ready to start a new phase in my life, appropriately titled "I Love Everybody," and it was going to be a good day to test out my new niceness, especially as I was headed to Costco to pick up my nephew's birthday cake before his party.

I Love Everybody

LORI: Two miles from Costco, all is going well until a Chevy two-ton crosses two empty lanes of traffic to squeal in front of me and then reduces its speed to that of a Fred Flintstone car. As I passed the truck, I smiled and I nodded. "Aren't you delightful?" I said, to which he stuck his big, filthy tongue into his cheek and vigorously moved it around as he

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raised his eyebrows repeatedly. I laughed and said through my smiling, clenched teeth, "Nice."

I Love Most Everybody

LORI: "Hi, how are you?" I said to people passing by who smiled at me, had some sort of visible ailment or challenge, or were in my way, which I figured would earn me more karma nice points, as I had a lot of catching up to do.

It was almost noon, and in Costco, that translates into a free hors d'oeuvres lunch. So I got in line, waiting for my free whatever it was. It was almost my turn, there were only two girls, who looked to be in their very early twenties, ahead of me.

At that precise moment, a sharp, high-pitched noise erupted in front of me that used my ear as a portal to repeatedly stab at my brain: *Brrrring! Brrrring!*

1st GIRL: That's you! *Brrrring! Brrrring!* Stab! Stab!

2nd GIRL: It is so totally not me! *Brrrring! Brrrring!* Stab! Stab!

LORI: *Answer* the *stupid* phone, I said silently as I tried in vain to turn my head to avoid the auditory assault -- finally forced to cup my hands over my ears. Then the first girl finally opened up her fishing net of a purse and began to dig through it to find the source. She grabbed it, unfolded it, and held it up to her ear.

1st GIRL: Hel-lo! HEL-LO-OH! . . . . *(looks sadly at her friend)* They hung up.

2nd GIRL: Ohhhhhh . . . . maybe they'll call back!

SAMPLE LADY: Cherry, raspberry, peach or blueberry?

1st GIRL: I don't know. What're you going to get?

2nd GIRL: I don't know. What're you going to get?

LORI: THE BLUEBERRY IS THE BEST! JUST GET THAT, PLEASE, YOU TWO VERY DELIGHTFUL GIRLS IN PRETTY DRESSES! I said as I felt the uncontrollable desire to cover my head and rock back and forth.

1st GIRL: This is a skort, not a dress!

LORI: BLUEBERRY! The sample lady handed them the little paper pill cup and they walked away.

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I Love Everybody, but Some People Are Simply Undeserving of the Love

LORI: I needed to hurry. I got to the bakery counter, and as the baker was in the process of getting my cake, another customer, a lady with big hair, frosted in chunks, wearing a sleeveless oxford shirt with very tanned arms like tree trunks and far too much pungent perfume, came to the counter and yelled, waving her diamond-encrusted hand at the bakery lady.

BIG HAIR LADY: Ma'am! Ma'am! I only have a question, this will only take a second!

BAKERY LADY: I'll be right with you.

BIG HAIR LADY: I'm sure this girl can wait, this will only take a second, and it's important. That carrot cake you have over there, do you have any without walnuts? I can't eat walnuts. I am peanut sensitive.

LORI: I took a deep breath.

BAKERY LADY: Those aren't our cakes. I don't know what they have in them. They come from other vendors.

BIG HAIR LADY: But my tongue gets big, very swollen. I have a reaction because of an allergy and it could almost kill me.

BAKERY LADY: Maybe you should try a chocolate cake, then.

BIG HAIR LADY: No, I can't, I'm on a diet.

LORI: The big-armed peanut hater turned her cart and rolled away before I could walk over and punch her.

Now, finally, with cake in hand, I sped toward the exit. I was making really good time. I was almost through the freezer section when my speedy progress came to a complete halt due to a lady in front of me, pushing her cart at a snail's pace, her arms crossed over the handle of the cart as she leaned on it like the very lazy person she apparently was. I tried to get around her several times, but oncoming traffic in the freezer section was at a bottleneck. I couldn't get around her, and she was making no effort whatsoever to pick up the pace, and I was stuck.

I tightly clutched the handle of my own cart, chanting with a clenched jaw over and over

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again like a mantra, "I Love Everybody, I Love Everybody, I Love Everybody, I Love Everybody," until I saw a break in cart traffic ahead and geared myself, getting ready to make a break for it.

I jerked forward, clipping the slow, lazy lady's heel in the process. When I was merely two steps behind her, I could no longer hold it in; my Bounty paper towel of patience could sop up no more. I had had enough of the walnut lady, the cell phone girls, the truck guy, and now the slow walker, and I could take no more. And I let it out, loud and clear, so the slow walker would absolutely hear -- "Here's an idea! Why don't you just drop to all fours and crawl through the store! That just might be slower!"

And it worked. She did indeed hear me. She turned to look at me, although she couldn't turn too much because that would have ripped the tube that was connected to her oxygen tank, which was sitting in her cart, right out of her nose. Right out of her nose. And both nostrils, too. Those tubes looked pretty short to me, as she leaned over to make sure they stayed in to keep her, well, alive.

I knew I had just RSVP'ed for my own personal spot in hell, right next to the Skin Pit, across from the Pool of Sin. Forty minutes into my nice-person experiment and I was already out of the game. I ducked down a side aisle, waiting until all witnesses to my meltdown had dispersed throughout the store. I should be ashamed of myself. I couldn't even be nice for a whole hour.

That's when I finally looked up and found myself right back at the freezer department, square in front of the sample ladies, who were busy frying, toasting, and handing out free food. Free food. Well, why not? I said to myself, and walked over to the sample lady whose crowd was the smallest, although I couldn't help but notice a big, frosted head sticking out like a sore thumb. I smiled the biggest grin I had all day when I saw the sample lady was cutting up delicious-looking cookies, and I nodded at her as I helped myself to one.

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Someone from behind suddenly bumped me, and without an "Excuse me" or "Pardon me," I saw a big, tanned, diamond encrusted arm that looked awfully familiar reach up to the sample tray and grab two cookie pieces like a goblin then suddenly retreat, almost if on cue.

I turned around and there she was -- her big, frosted head opening wide to pop in the cookie bits. I waited until she chewed a couple of times and I saw her swallow.

I was a bad girl. A bad girl with nothing to lose.

"These are the most wonderful cookies I have ever eaten in my life!" I said as loudly as I could, then turned to the frosted chewing head, who nodded vigorously in agreement. It was then that I embarked on a huge Opportunity to Enlighten with a bold-faced, nutty lie. "Don't you just love chocolate chip walnut cookies? I am *crazy* about these walnuts!!"

I Tried to Love Everybody, but Sometimes, You Just Have to Hate a Little Too.

LORI: And, with that, I turned back to the sample lady and smiled. "That is a delightful hair net and apron you're wearing."

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier - MS
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
NIETOC
FL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
ND State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier
SD State Qualifier